ON THE GAU...

19 million
Number of cows in UP

1.18 million
Stray cattle in UP

5,617
Cow protection centres in UP

789,000
No. of cows in *gaushalas*

140,000
Cows distributed under various government schemes

150
No. of illegal slaughterhouses that have been shut down in the past five years

an increase in bovine-related violence, including lynching. The number of cow protection centres in the state has gone up to 5,617 from 586 such centres for destitute cows in urban centres. The government has also set up 3,458 *bhoosa* or fodder banks across districts and arranged 887,000 quintal of fodder for cattle it prefers to call *nirashrit* (without shelter) rather than *awara*. The state has also come up with an adopt-a-cow scheme. Under the Nirashrit Besahara Govansh Sahbhagita Yojana, people are given an incentive of Rs 30 a day per cow for taking care of up to four cows. Some 120,000 animals have been given out to 54,000 people under the scheme, claims Sudhir Garg, principal secretary in the animal husbandry department of the state. In January 2019, the state imposed a cow cess of half a per cent on excise items like alcohol and a one per cent levy on *mandi parishad*s or marketing committees.

And yet the problem persists.

So much so that farmers have been clamouring for political parties to include it in their election manifestos if they wanted their votes. Opposition parties were quick to jump onto the bandwagon. In December, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav promised a compensation of Rs 5 lakh to the families of those whose kin have been killed in bovine attacks if his party came to power. He also brought up the subject at his rallies before this announcement.

SP spokesperson Manoj Kaka is convinced it is a significant poll issue. "Earlier, people used to treat cattle as '*pashudhan*' (animal wealth) because milk sales earned them an income and they were useful in the fields. Now they call them *awara pashu* because their numbers have gone up so much they are out of control." According to Garg, UP currently has a total cow population of 19 million. Of these, 1.1 million can be characterised as cows without owners.

"Even *pashu mela*s have been stopped in this regime where farmers could sell cattle," adds SP's Kaka. "*Gaushala*s (cow shelters) and *sanrakshan kendra*s (protection centres), on the other hand, have become exemplars of mismanagement. As a result, you find cows roaming the highways and markets causing accidents, or in the fields, where they are ruining crops."

On October 16, 2021, 11 people, including seven women and four children, mostly from the same family, died and another half a dozen were injured in Chirgaon near Jhansi when a tractor trolley overturned while trying to save stray cattle. The incident caused enough of a furore for CM Adityanath to instruct his officials to ensure proper treatment for the injured. On November 22 the same year, he also asked all district magistrates to ensure all destitute cattle was kept in cow shelters and did not roam the streets.

UP Congress chief Ajay Lallu says he found people talking about the issue wherever he went. "Hundreds of people have been killed in the state in bovine attacks, but the government has no figures. A farmer's life has no value for them. If we form the government, we will give compensation of Rs 3,000 per acre to farmers who have lost their crop to stray cattle."

Bahujan Samaj Party state spokesperson Dr M.H. Khan, on the other hand, thinks the ruling regime has done cows a great disservice. "They claim to be *gau rakshak*s," he says, "but they are responsible for the pitiable condition of cows in the state." He believes cows, both in *gaushala*s as well as on the streets, are victims of neglect. He also thinks that a lot of fake cases of cow slaughter are being registered against people. "If we form the government, we will fight for justice for those who have been wrongly accused."

In the past five years, 150 illegal slaughterhouses have been shut down. Currently, only 35 slaughterhouses, perceived to be adhering to prescribed norms, are operating in UP. The state government also claims it had identified 356 cattle mafia groups and initiated action against 1,823 accused. It has also confiscated assets worth Rs 18 crore from 68 smugglers booked under the UP Gangsters and Anti-social Activities (Prevention) Act.

UP BJP spokesperson Rakesh Tripathi denies that stray cattle is an issue in these polls. While acknowledging that the shutdown of illegal slaughterhouses and the ban on cow smuggling had contributed to the rising number of stray cows, he said the government's initiatives such as the cow adoption and Poshan mission schemes will go a long way in resolving the issue. Then, tapping into Hindutva sentiment, he dangles the threat that slaughter of the holy animal will begin again as SP men are not exactly cow lovers. "In 2019 too, they tried to make it a poll issue," says Tripathi, "but failed. This time, too, they will not be able to make political capital out of the issue. Our government's schemes will ensure cows are well looked after."

He is referring to the government's Poshan Mission under which families with undernourished children are provided cows so that they can get milk. According to government figures, 1,883 families have availed of this benefit till date and 1,894 destitute cows have found a home. Close to 789,000 cows are housed in *gaushala*s, he claims.

But is it enough to assuage the suffering of UP's farmers? That remains a moo point. ■